A Proposed Curriculum Change and First Period

By Richard Howard and Kevin M. Derring

INTRODUCTION

As many teachers know, the national discussion on education is overcrowded with opinions on teacher training, salaries, tenure, and unions -- with occasional detours through iPads, textbooks, and national policy. In fact, it seems that we listen to every interested party except *the one for whom education exists in the first place: students.*

This compilation looks at education through the eyes of students. In the first poem "A Proposed Curriculum Change" by Richard Howard, a fifth grade class wishes to change their "one-sided" school curriculum and composes a letter to the "powers that be" with the help of their teacher.

Dear Mrs Masters,

It's happened *again!*

and the whole Fifth-Grade Class is upset

(which is why we're *writing* again: you told us

to tell you when *"anything* related to

school" upsets the class,

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so now we're telling).

You see, just last week,

thanks to Mr Lee's

connections (that's what he calls the friends

who do him favors), our Fifth-Grade Science Class,

all twelve, until the Klein twins got mumps,

-together, of course-

and had to stay home,

so we invited

Mike Rahn and Clark Taft,

the two smartest kids in the Fourth-Grade,

to come instead, since Mr Lee had specified

there would be twelve students visiting

the Sandusky Labs

for our winter-term

science field trip, and

no one wants to sec

two favors go to waste. Dinny-that's

Mr Lee: he *asked* us all to call him that,

and now he's the one teacher at school

we're on first-name, or

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maybe nick-name terms
with ... whom. Anyway,
Dinny has this friend Mr Morton
who works in the Labs (he told us right away,
"Call me Mort, everyone does"-first names
must be a sort of
code for Scientists),
on the development
of cancerous tumors that he trained
to grow in mice *(induced* was the word he used).
When he offered to show us how
his experiment
was coming along,
Lucy Wensley asked
"Mr Mort" ifhe could tell one mouse
from the next: "Do you ever see something
individual about a mouse-
some particular
mouse you're working on?"
(Lucy sometimes brings
her pet guinea-pig to school with her,

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so of course she'd ask a thing like that.)
Her question really surprised Mort, but
maybe what he said
was a good answer;
after a moment
he told this story: last week he had
to kill a mouse with a newborn litter, and
to save her young, gave them to another
mouse to bring them up
with her own; and when
that experiment
worked, he gave that foster-mother mouse
another litter of newborn young, to see
what she would do. At first all went well:
the new babies were
fat and already
growing fur, though still
blind-and then one night she ate them all! ...
Not just Lucy but our whole Class, including
the two Fourth-Graders, listened without
saying anything.

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Nobody moved. Mort
opened the lab door,
saying "Boys and girls, please come with me"
and the spell was broken. But Mrs Masters,
no one has forgotten Mort's story.
Over and over
in Dinny's classes
we've learned this lesson:
In the Animal World-and aren't we
animals too?-mothers and fathers go
after their young, all shapes and sizes,
pigs in model farms,
Komodo dragons,
and now even mice!
Maybe our own parents will eat *us*
eventually-they may have eaten us
already, and the rest of our life
is just the process
of their digestion.
That's not our life, it's
our education, but it seems so ...

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one-sided! Maybe in Sixth-Grade, things will work
the other way around, so that sons
murder their fathers,
babies eat grownups,
and Snow White poisons
her wicked step-mother. So far that's
the best reason to leave Fifth-Grade behind us.
Still, we don't see why Science-at least
Dinny Lee's version –
has to be so ... so
animalistic.
That may be how life is, but we'd like
to put in a word-two words-for Other Things
we could learn at Park School, Duncan Chu
says that the right phrase
for what we mean is
human interest:
what we want to study at Park School
is how people have managed to *avoid*
behaving like animals, instead
of becoming them.

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Is Science only

a history of death?

Maybe we'll find out in Sixth-Grade that

no Fate is worse than death after all,

and that life is going to be ours.

Dear Mrs Masters,

if these suggestions

make sense to you, please

let us (and Dinny Lee) know about

what courses we'll be taking next year along

the lines we have designated here,

and the kind of books

we should be reading

over the summer.

(signed) Respectfully, the Fifth-Grade Class:

Judy Abrams, Nancy Akcrs,Jean Sturges, David

Halperin,

David Stashower, Jane McCullough,

Arthur Englander,

Anne Wiebe, Lois

Hexter, Jeunessc Ames,

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David McConnehey, Duncan Chu

and today's guests, Mike Rahn & Clark Taft

visiting from the Fourth-Grade Class

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Richard Howard
Book: The Best American Poetry 2012
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Date (Month/Year): September 2012

TRANSITION

You see, a one-size fits all curriculum is counter-productive. With the variety of student backgrounds, cultures and abilities; teachers are placed in an untenable situation. Trying to adhere to the curriculum requirements prescribed by the system while engaging students in class sizes that are often too large for individualized instruction has left many teachers feeling unappreciated, burned-out, used-up and frustrated . . . Teachers who once were devoted to their students have become less and less tolerant, less caring, less nurturing and more and more frustrated.

That's the word that is heard most often from teachers . . . frustrated. And ultimately it is the student who bears the brunt of that frustration. Now, don't get me wrong, there are still inspiring, devoted teachers out there; but the system has also created teachers like the one in First Period by Kevin M. Derring

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half way through first period
dust accumulated on the sweaty palm of my
raised hand
must be a centimeter thick by now
as the chicken-legged teacher goes around the
room
defacing students' homework from last night
with red pen graffiti
that focuses more on missed commas than the
content of the sentences
he finally decides to acknowledge me
"Mr. Derrig, why do I have a feeling that this is
another one of your dumb
comments. You constantly waste my time. Why
don't you just drop out or something?"

why don't I just drop out
why don't I just drop out!
and it was at that moment that all statistics
began to make sense to me
statistics of children whose mouths water more

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for the many taste of
society corner slanged penicillins
than the cardboard textures of diplomas
with pipes more important to fill
than class requirements
statistics of classes cut
to avoid battlefields full of aggravated shrapnel
from teachers with exploding tempers
teachers with magnifying glasses at the end
pointers
who feed off the brightness of surrounding
students
to singe holes in the esteems of those who need
just a little more help
than
others
I wanted to turn my shot-down hand into a fist
I wanted to hit him 'til he was incapable of
speaking anymore
but I didn't want to become another number in
overflowing manila folders

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of children arrested in school
and we wonder why a gun seems to fit perfectly
        in the hands of this generation's adolescents
ladies and gentlemen
I'm writing this poem to highlight that which has
        been stuck like gum
underneath wobbly desks
free from parental eyes
only to mess the hand of those who have to sit
there
I'm writing this poem to speak for all the rows of
        children before me
who remained voiceless in the cracks of school
        and its soundproof textbooks
I'm writing this poem for all the children who
        have not yet been named
the ones that will one day have to fill these rows
        I've been struggling in
only to enter classrooms where they'll be shot
        down for what they feel
ladies and gentlemen

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the future of America is being crushed between
        the molars
of power-hungry tyrants who think class rooms
        are boot camps
and if we have any teachers in the audience
I urge you to understand that the hand you grab
        the chalk with
the hand you grab those red pens with
the voices you speak with
are oversized chisels
and you must proceed to teach with caution
for what you say and what you do is written in
        stone
and if you chisel too hard these minds can crack
"So what don't you understand now, Mr. Derrig?"
I just wanted to know if I could go to the bathroom

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Kevin M. Derrig
Book: The Spoken Word Revolution: Slam, Hip Hop & the Poetry of a New Generation
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AWARD HISTORY

2010 National Qualifier

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